

Dive Deeper into Japanese Language

-Particle 'で'(/de/)-

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For Japanese version, click [here](#)

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About Me

- Accounts
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- Occupation: Software Engineer
- Things I Am Into
 - Linguistics
 - Singing at Karaoke
 - Listening to Music
 - Watching Movies
 - Cat Feeding



Licences / Certifications

- English
 - TOEIC® Listening & Reading 915: Certified on December 2019
- Engineering
 - Information Security Management: Certified on November 2017
 - Applied Information Technology Engineer: Certified on June 2017
 - Fundamental Information Technology Engineer: Certified on November 2016
 - IT Passport: Certified on April 2016
- Others
 - Abacus 2nd Class: Certified on June 2002
 - Mental Arithmetic 3rd Class: Certified on February 2001

Skill Stack

- Languages
 - Japanese: Native Proficiency
 - English: Full professional Proficiency
- Development
 - **Backend: Ruby(Ruby on Rails), Python**
 - Frontend: TypeScript + React.js, TypeScript +Vue.js
 - **Database: MySQL, PostgreSQL, MongoDB**
 - **Architecture: Monolith, Modular Monolith**
 - Hosting: AWS ESK
 - Versioning: Git, GitHub
 - **CI/CD: GitHub Actions, ArgoCD**
 - Monitoring: Datadog, Sentry

Work Histories

Period	Genre	Position	Jobs
Aug 2021 - Present	SaaS(Educational Service)	Software Engineer	• Backend Development • Frontend Development • CI/CD Maintenance • Weekly Release Manager • Troubleshooting • Documentation • Technical Debt Resolution • Tech Blog Entries • LT Speaker
Feb 2020 - Dec 2020	SaaS(Chatbot Platform)	Backend Engineer	• Backend Development • Documentation • Technical Debt Resolution • Inspection of Alternative API

Work Histories

Period	Genre	Position	Jobs
Jun 2018 - Jan 2020	Contract-basis Developer	Software Engineer	• Backend Development • Frontend Development • Troubleshooting • Quality Assurance • Tech Blog Entries
Apr 2016 - Jan 2018	System Engineering Service	System Engineer	• Corporate Account Admin • Windows Server Maintenance • Security Admin Assistant • Internationalisation / Localisation

International-Exchange Activities

- Activities in University
 - English Linguistics Seminar(Focusing on Mass Media English)
 - International-Exchange Clubs(The 2nd Year)
 - [International-Exchange Programmes conducted by Japan Cabinet Office](#)(2013 - 2016)
 - Japanese Linguistics Course(The Final Year)
- Overseas Life Experience
 - Working Holiday in Australia(April 2014 - March 2015)
 - Language School for 1 month in Sydney
 - Work for 6 Months in [Hamilton Island Resort](#)
 - Volunteering for 1 Month as Assistant Teacher of Japanese Language at [St Ives High School](#) in NSW
- Other Activities
 - Keep Everyday Journal in English (April 2014 - Present)
 - [Sunrise Toastmasters Club](#)(February 2017 - March 2018)
 - [Vital Japan](#)(January 2018 - July 2019, October 2022 - February 2023)
 - Self Learning and Training of English Language
 - Participation Ruby-Related Tech Conferences

Agenda

1. [The Main Theme](#)
2. [Prologue -で of みんなで-](#)
3. [Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 1 -Spatial Functions-](#)
4. [Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 2 -Role Functions-](#)
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Japanese language (Nihongo)

1. The Main Theme

日本語

1. The Main Theme

When I grammatically analyse a Japanese particle, it turned out that it was a lot more difficult than English grammar.

I will discuss how profound it is and share as easy a description as possible.

日本語

Japanese language (Nihongo)

2. Prologue -で of みんなで-

日本語

2. Prologue -で of みんなで-

I worked as an assistant teacher of Japanese language at [St Ives High School](#) in NSW on February 2015 for a month.

One day, a student ask me the following .

I'd like to ask you about a Japanese particle. If I say, "I will pick you up at the airport with everyone tomorrow." in Japanese, it is supposed to be 明日空港にみんなであなただを迎えに行きます, but I don't understand why I have to use で, instead of は or が though みんな seems the subject in this sentence. Would you explain why?

2. Prologue -で of みんなで-

Summary of the Provided Question

- みんな(*everyone*) is the actor of 迎えに行く (*to pick you up*), so みんな is supposed to be the subject in the Japanese sentence.
- Notwithstanding, the actual subject is absent in the original sentence and みんな plays a role in a modifier. Why is it followed by で, not は(topic marker) or が(subject marker).

2. Prologue -で of みんなで-

I thought the question hit the mark, but I was not sure of the answer at all.

As an assistant teacher, I was ashamed of my ignorance and provided the following response.

I'm sorry but I'm not sure of the details. I'm afraid it is because of its collocation.

2. Prologue -で of みんなで-

As soon as I returned home, I looked up で in the 5th version of Kojien Japanese Dictionary, which showed me the following definitions.

1. Place • Time • Occasion where an action is taken
2. Means • Way • Tool • Material
3. Reason • Cause
4. Scene
5. Status • Qualification
6. Affair • Condition
7. Period • Range
8. Standard of distribution

2. Prologue -で of みんなで-

Japanese language (Nihongo)

There was NO ANSWER I was looking for!

2. Prologue -で of みんなで-

After all, I brought the question back to my home country.

I returned to university and took a Japanese linguistics class in the autumn semester, where I submitted a term paper whose theme was *The Role and Grammatical Structure of the Japanese Particle で*.

I made sense of the profound riddle and won the S credit.

It would be happy if I may share as clear explanations of what I learned as possible.

Japanese language (Nihongo)

3. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 1 -Spatial Functions-

日本語

3. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 1 -Spatial Functions-

3-1. Place → <Place Abstraction> → Occasion

□ Place

2004年のオリンピックはアテネで開かれた。

The 2004 Olympic Games were held in Athens.

- It represents **the visible object** *Athens*.

□ Occasion

彼は自然に恵まれた環境で育った。

He was raised in a region richly endowed with nature.

- It represents **the invisible object** *nature*.

3. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 1 -Spatial Functions-

3-2. Place → <Focus on Scope • Subjection of Action> → Scope

彼はこのクラスで 1 番背が高い。

He is tallest (of all students) in this class.

- **The concrete place** *this class* has been transformed to the usage of **limitation of the subjective scope**.
- The usage has finally expanded to **the objective scope** *this class* where *he* is searched for.

3. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 1 -Spatial Functions-

3-3. Place → <Backgrounding of Place> → Actor

その事件は警察で調べている。

The case is being examined by the police.

- Police is a group of police officers and it has turned to **backgrounding of a place**, which finally has been transformed to **the place where the actor *police* is closely concerned.**
- Subject(the case) ≠ Actor(the police)

3. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 1 -Spatial Functions-

3-4. Place → <Metaphor> → <Focus on Time Scope>→ Limitation of Timing

□ 食事の後で勉強する。 (*Someone will study just after a meal.*)

- *After a meal* has changed from space of **place** to that of **time**.
- This usage represents **time and space as a scene where an action is taken**, so it lays more emphasis on **limitation the scope of time**.

□ 食事の後に勉強する。 (*Someone will study after a meal.*)

- It also represents limitation of the scope of timing, but it **does not mention a place**.
- On the other hand, で has a more specific usage as limitation of time and space.

Japanese language (Nihongo)

4. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 2 -Role Functions-

日本語

4. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 2 -Role Functions-

4-1. Place → <Role of Background> → <Internalised Tools • Means> → Material • Component

□ Tools and Means

日本人は箸で食事をする。

Japanese people (usually) have a meal with chopsticks.

- It represents a **concrete and individual place where pressure is put.**

□ Material or Component

この机は木でできている。

This desk is made of wood.

- It represents a **inclusive place which is less individual and more subject to something else.**

4. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 2 -Role Functions-

4-2. Tool → <Active Backgrounding> → Cause → Reason • Argument • Purpose • Component

□ Cause

病気で学校を休む。 (*Someone is absent from school with illness.*)

- The relation between the cause and result is more **highly objective**.

□ Reason

そういう点で面白いと思う。 (*It is interesting in the sense.*)

□ Argument

試験の結果で判断する。 (*Something is judge from the result of examination.*)

□ Purpose

出張で大阪へ行ってきた。 (*Someone went to Osaka as a business trip.*)

- The recognition of the incident depends on the person, so it is **subjective**.

□ Component

日本の文化というテーマで論文を書いた。 (*Someone wrote a paper whose theme is Japanese culture.*)

- It represents a component consisting of something, so it implies **a cause, tool and material**.

4. Cognitive Linguistical Analysis 2 -Role Functions-

4-3. Tool → <Abstraction of Tool> → Mode

All of the following usages represent an internalised or recursive tool.

☐ Mode of Actor

食事は自分で作っている。 (*I make a meal by myself.*)

- It represents the mode of the actor who makes a meal by themselves with oneself **as a recursive tool**.
- Subject(I) = Actor(I)

☐ Mode of Receiver

小さい音で音楽を聴く。 (*Someone listens to music in a low volume.*)

- It represents the mode of the receiver of *sound* of music **as an internal tool**.

☐ Mode of Influence • Incident

猛スピードで走っている。 (*Something is running at a high speed.*)

- It represents **the internal tool of a high speed making something run**.

☐ 数量限定

この部屋は 30 人でいっぱいになる。 (*This room is full up with 30 people.*)

- It represents **the external tool of 30 people filling up the room**.

Japanese language (Nihongo)

5. True Identity of で of みんなで

日本語

5. True Identity of で of みんなで

「明日空港にみんなであなただを迎えに行きます。」

で in the above has in either of the following usages.

- **Actor in Spatial Functions:** その事件は警察で調べている。 (*The case is being examine by the police.*)
- **Mode of Actor in Role Functions:** 食事は自分で作っている。 (*I make a meal by myself.*)

The key difference is the equality of the relation between **the subject and the actor**.

5. True Identity of で of みんなで

To supplement the omitted subjects, each sentence is supposed to be as follows.

- 「(私は)明日空港にみんなであなたを迎えに行きます。」
 - I will pick you up at the airport with **everyone**.
 - → Subject(I) ≠ Actor(everyone)
- **Actor in Spatial Functions:** 「その事件は警察で調べている。」
 - The case is being examined by **the police**.
 - → Subject(The case) ≠ Actor(the police)
- **Mode of Actor in Role Functions:** 「(私は)食事は自分で作っている。」
 - I make a meal by **myself**.
 - → Subject(I) = Actor(myself)

The true identity of で of みんなで is the **Mode of Actor in Role Functions**.

※ If the subject is 私たち(*we*) instead of 私(*I*), the equality of the relation between the subject(*we*) and Actor(everyone = *us*) makes sense, which represents the **Mode of Actor in Role Functions**.

Japanese language (Nihongo)

6. Summary

日本語

6. Summary

'で' has the following 2 cognitive linguistic functions as follows.

1. Spatial Functions

- Place → <Place Abstraction> → Occasion
- Place → <Focus on Scope · Subjection of Action> → Scope
- Place → <Backgrounding of Place> → Actor
- Place → <Metaphor> → <Focus on Time Scope> → Limitation of Timing

2. Role Functions

- Place → <Role of Background> → <Internalised Tools · Means> → Material · Component
- Tool → <Active Backgrounding> → Cause → Reason · Argument · Purpose · Component
- Tool → <Abstraction of Tool> → Mode

Japanese language (Nihongo)

7. Epilogue

日本語

7. Epilogue

One of the key differences between Japanese language and English language is the existence of particle.

Proposition follows a word in English while particle is followed by a word in Japanese.

Just as learners of English language think of nuances of propositions of English as highly difficult, those of Japanese language see usage of particles as magnificently profound.

For native Japanese speakers, they will find how difficult it is once they observe it from the point of view as a foreign language.

A Japanese particle was a good example.

Japanese language (Nihongo)

8. References

日本語

8. References

- Shin Moriyama, *認知言語学から見た日本語格助詞の意味構造と習得*, Tokyo, ひつじ書房, 2008
- *広辞苑第五版*, Tokyo, 岩波書店, 2006

日本語

Japanese language (Nihongo)

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日本語